United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization

Intangible Cultural Heritage

Introducing the Convention

Unit 2 PowerPoint presentation

UNESCO
Intangible Cultural Heritage Section

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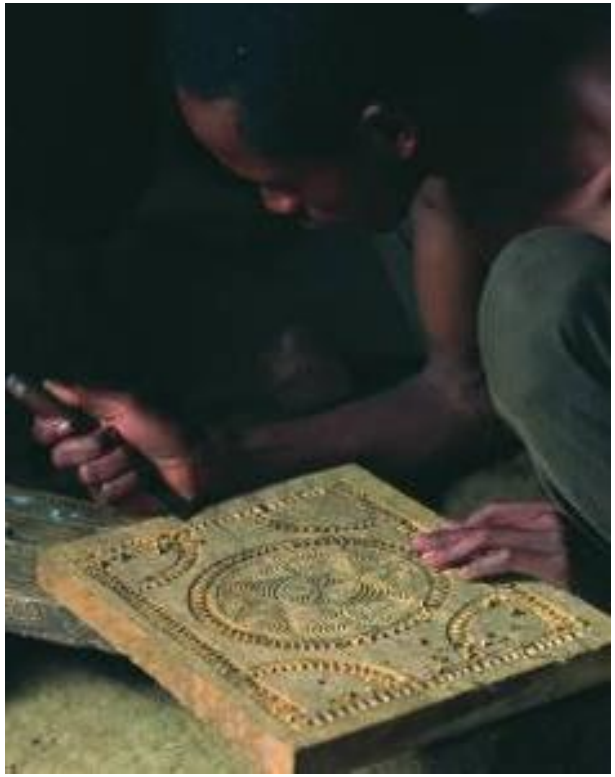
In this presentation …



The Woodcrafting Knowledge of the Zafimaniry
© J. Ségur/ZED
Inscribed on the RL in 2008

UNESCO and its Conventions

The Intangible Heritage Convention

- Purposes of the Convention
- Organs of the Convention
- Two Lists and a Register
- Operational Directives (ODs)
- ICH Fund
- Obligations and benefits

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UNESCO and its Conventions

Intergovernmental organization with 195 Member States

Five sectors: Education, Natural Sciences, Social & Human Sciences, Culture and Communication & Information

Seven UNESCO Conventions in the fields of culture and heritage:

•tangible, intangible and natural heritage

•diversity of cultural expressions

•copyright

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Three related UNESCO Conventions on culture and heritage

There are three related UNESCO conventions on culture and heritage:

•Convention concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage (1972)

•Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage (2003)

•Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions (2005)

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Comparing two Conventions (1)

World Heritage (1972)

- Conservation of World Heritage properties
- Cultural and/or natural
- Outstanding universal value
- Authenticity and integrity help to define value, often restricting change

Intangible Heritage (2003)

- Safeguarding of all ICH expressions, skills, practices and knowledge
- Cultural and/or social
- Communities concerned define value
- ICH changes over time

Comparing two Conventions (2)

Diversity of Cultural Expressions (2005)

- Cultural activities, goods and services (products)
- Cultural expressions: often new, individual creations
- Focus on cultural industries, dissemination and development

Intangible Heritage (2003)

- Skills, practices, expressions and knowledge
- ICH is a collective practice, transmitted ‘from generation to generation’
- Focus on safeguarding practice and transmission of ICH

Contents of the Intangible Heritage Convention

- Preamble
- Purposes of the Convention (Article 1)
- Definitions (Article 2)
- Organs of the Convention (Articles 4–10)
- Safeguarding – national level (Articles 11–15)
- Lists and Register (Articles 16–18)
- International cooperation and assistance (Articles 19-24)
- ICH Fund (Articles 25–28)
- Reporting (Articles 29–30)
- Ratification, etc. (Articles 32–33)

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Objectives of the Convention

Article 1

- Safeguarding
- Respect
- Awareness and mutual appreciation
- International cooperation and assistance

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The two Lists of the Convention

- Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity – RL (Article 16)
- List of Intangible Cultural Heritage in Need of Urgent Safeguarding – USL (Article 17)

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Sanké mon: collective fishing rite of the Sanké

© Direction Nationale du Patrimoine Culturel, Ministère de la Culture du Mali, 2009

The Sanké mon collective fishing rite takes place annually in the Ségou region of Mali to mark the beginning of the rainy season and commemorate the founding of the town of San.

In recent years, fewer people have attended the rite because of diminishing awareness of its function and history, occasional accidents and the degradation of the Sanké lake.

Inscribed on the USL in 2009.

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The Tango

© Ministerio de Cultura de Argentina, Ciudad de Buenos Aires, 2008

The Tango is a symbol of the popular culture of Argentina and Uruguay, especially their capital cities. Originating in the working-class neighbourhoods of Buenos Aires and Montevideo, the Tango dates back to the late nineteenth century. Practised spontaneously and in more formal settings, it enjoys great popularity, both locally and worldwide.

Inscribed on the RL in 2009.

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Register of Good Safeguarding Practices

© Centre for Traditional Culture, School Museum of Pusol, 2010

Article 18

School Museum of Pusol (Spain)

Guided by teachers, children explore the rich heritage of Elche by working with tradition bearers and documenting their heritage.

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Organs of the Convention

General Assembly: sovereign body of the Convention. All States Parties are members.

Intergovernmental Committee: twenty-four Member States; implements the Convention.

UNESCO Secretariat: serves the Organs; assists in implementing the Convention.

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Operational Directives

- Guide implementation of the Convention
- Include regulations and procedures for Lists, Register and Fund as well as reporting obligations
- Prepared by Committee, approved by General Assembly
- First set approved 2008; amended and enlarged in 2012 and 2014

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Intangible Cultural Heritage Fund

Articles 25–28

- Mainly supports safeguarding, inventory-making, capacity building
- States Parties contribute to the Fund
- Some States make additional contributions
- States Parties may request financial assistance, singly or jointly
- Few requests for assistance received so far

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Exercise (20 mins): obligations of States Parties to the Convention

In Articles 11–15 and 26–29 of the Convention, please identify where it says:

- ‘States Parties shall ...’
- ‘States Parties undertake …’
- ‘States Parties shall endeavour to ...’

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Obligations of States Parties to the Convention

- Safeguard ICH on their territory (Article 11(a))
- Ensure community participation in identifying, defining and managing their ICH (Articles 11(b) and 15)
- Draw up inventories of the ICH in their territory (Article 12.1)
- Contribute to the ICH Fund (Article 26)
- Report to the Committee (Article 29)

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Benefits of implementing the Convention (1)

Better safeguarding of the ICH within the States Parties, contributing to:

- Well-being of communities
- Respect and understanding between communities
- Sustainable development
- Enhancement of cultural diversity and human creativity

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Benefits of implementing the Convention (2)

International cooperation and assistance:

- Sharing expertise and information internationally
- Sharing safeguarding practices
- Accessing assistance from the Fund
- Nominating elements and safeguarding projects
- Participating in the Organs of the Convention
- Cooperating regionally and internationally: for example, on shared heritage

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In conclusion (1)

The Convention aims at:

•Safeguarding ICH within and by communities in a context of sustainable development and mutual respect

•Fully involving communities in any action concerning their ICH and empowering communities

•Enhancing cultural diversity, human creativity, mutual understanding and international cooperation

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In conclusion (2)

The Convention:

•Is run by an Intergovernmental Committee, controlled by a General Assembly, both assisted by the UNESCO Secretariat

•Has Operational Directives, a Fund, two Lists and a Register of Good Practices

•Ratification imposes some obligations on States Parties

•Implementation brings benefits for States Parties, the communities concerned and other stakeholders

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